This thick soup from northern Italy is guaranteed to keep out the winter chills. Soak the beans overnight to rehydrate them and cut down on the cooking time.

white bean soup

SERVES 4 **PREP** 30 MINS **COOK** 2 HRS **FREEZE** UP TO 3 MONTHS
AT THE END OF STEP 3

3 tbsp olive oil
2 onions, finely chopped
2 garlic cloves, crushed
8oz (225g) dried cannellini beans, soaked overnight
1 celery rib, chopped
1 bay leaf
3–4 parsley stems, without leaves
1 tbsp lemon juice
1¼ quarts (1¼ liters) vegetable stock
salt and freshly ground black pepper
3 shallots, thinly sliced
2oz (60g) pancetta, chopped (optional)
3oz (85g) Fontina or Taleggio cheese, chopped into small pieces

1 Heat 2 tbsp olive oil in a saucepan, add the onions, and cook over low heat for 10 minutes, or until softened, stirring occasionally. Add the garlic and cook, stirring, for 1 minute.

2 Drain the soaked beans and add to the pan with the celery, bay leaf, parsley stems, lemon juice, and stock. Bring to a boil, cover, and simmer for 1½ hours, or until the beans are soft, stirring occasionally.

3 Remove the bay leaf and process the soup in batches in a blender, or through a hand mill. Rinse out the pan. Return the soup to the pan and season to taste with salt and pepper.

4 Heat the remaining olive oil in a small frying pan, and cook the shallots and pancetta (if using) until golden and crisp, stirring frequently to keep them from sticking to the pan. Reheat the soup, adding a little stock or water if it is too thick. Stir the Fontina into the soup. Ladle into individual bowls, and sprinkle each serving with the shallots and pancetta.